

THE CREATURE BEFORE GOD

Part II

The Due Return

Religion and the Justice of Creaturehood

From unowed gift and commanded good
to hope and the freedom of a living sacrifice

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1 The Question after Vertigo

The first movement reached two judgments: *I am, and I am not from myself*. The source who needs nothing freely wills created good: God loves. Neither judgment waits for permission. A creature depends upon its source before it understands, welcomes, or resists that dependence. The question is not how to make the asymmetry disappear, but how intellect, will, body, and common life can be brought into agreement with it. Once apprehended, the truth addresses the creature as one capable of answering: *What is due from one who has received everything by which an answer can be made?*

St. Paul places the question within an apparent contradiction. “Who has given [God] anything that he may be repaid?” The answer is no one. “From him and through him and for him are all things” (Rom 11:35–36). No creature reaches behind the first gift, supplies a divine lack, or makes God its debtor. Paul then draws a practical conclusion: “therefore,” by the mercies of God, offer your bodies as a living sacrifice and spiritual worship (Rom 12:1). The denial of repayment does not end the return. It purifies it.

The distinction is exact. Before I existed, being was not owed to me. Because I exist from God and for God, worship is owed by me. The second sentence does not reverse the first. Creation is not a contract in which a recipient first accepts goods and later receives an invoice. The due arises within the real order established by the gift: a rational creature can recognize its first principle and last end, and can direct its acts accordingly.

Governing thesis

The unowed gift of creaturehood establishes a real but unequal due. The rational creature ought freely to acknowledge God as first principle and last end through worship and through justice toward the neighbor. In Christian life this return takes the form of a living sacrifice incorporated into Christ’s own offering. Natural and revealed law articulate this order; ecclesiastical law gives determinate common form to some practices by which it is lived; grace gives the power to answer, and hope relies upon that help. The asymmetry remains; action begins to accord with it.

The title *due return* therefore names neither equivalent repayment nor an exchange of benefits. It names a morally fitting response to a relation that is already true. God receives no new actuality from the response; the creature is perfected by rendering it. The return is not a thought held at a distance. It claims intellect, will, body, time, possessions, and common life.

Ontological dependence and moral obligation must nevertheless remain distinct. Dependence is the fact; obligation concerns the fitting act of a rational will. Sin can reject the order of the due, but it cannot repeal creaturehood. Conversely, metaphysics alone does not specify every commandment, sacrament, holy day, or ecclesiastical precept. The movement from dependence to a concrete Christian life passes through natural reason, revelation, covenant, the authority of the Church, prudence, and grace.

That movement is the subject of this article. It begins with the impossibility of putting God in our debt. It passes through religion and the living sacrifice, then asks how gift, command, natural law, and ecclesiastical precept belong together. Sunday supplies a bounded example of how the worship owed to God takes common form; mercy proves that the return cannot terminate in cult severed from the neighbor. The movement ends where justice opens into hope: not with duty canceled, but with the Giver also giving the power to answer.

2 The Gift That Cannot Be Repaid

2.1 No divine lack to fill

The first error is to imagine worship as divine maintenance. If praise, sacrifice, or obedience completed God, the Creator would depend upon the creature in the very order the creature is asked to acknowledge. The asymmetry would collapse.

Irenaeus rejects that picture directly. God did not form Adam because he needed a human being upon whom to depend. Before creation, the Word glorified the Father. Nor did God command service because he needed human obedience. Those who follow the light do not illuminate it; they are illuminated. Service profits God nothing, while the servant receives life, incorruption, and communion with God (*Against Heresies* IV.14.1–2). The point governs

Irenaeus's treatment of sacrifice as well. God does not hunger for oblations. He teaches a people to turn from idols, to practice justice, and to offer from a rightly ordered heart (IV.17.1; 18.1–6).

This conclusion is not merely negative. Divine non-need explains why command can be beneficent without becoming self-interested. We do not serve to supply a lack in God. We serve because we lack God. The command brings no gain to the One who commands; it directs the one commanded toward communion with the good that no creature can produce for itself.

Aquinas reaches the same point through the virtue of religion. We offer to God not for his usefulness but for his glory and our good (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 6, ad 2). “Glory” here is not an increase in divine excellence. It is the creature’s manifestation and acknowledgment of an excellence already infinite. Right worship creates no new truth about God; it brings the worshipper’s act into conformity with truth.

2.2 A due established within gift

If God owes no creature the original gift of existence, how can a due arise at all? Aquinas distinguishes the orders carefully. God is not directed to creatures as to an end that perfects him. Within the order willed by divine wisdom, however, God gives each created nature what belongs to its condition; created dues are real but derivative (ST I, q. 21, a. 1, ad 3). The creature likewise possesses goods, powers, relations, and ends from which genuine obligations follow.

The due return therefore begins after the gift, not before it. A nonexistent recipient has no antecedent claim to be created. An existing rational creature is nevertheless capable of acting fittingly or unfittingly toward the source from whom it exists. It can acknowledge truth or suppress it, honor the good or prefer a lesser good as ultimate, render justice or withhold it.

This avoids two opposite errors. The first turns gift into contract: God gives in order to exact an equivalent. The second turns gift into moral indifference: because the gift was free, no response can be owed. A gift need not create commercial equivalence in order to establish a relation with moral form. The child’s debt of honor to a parent, for example, is neither payment for conception nor a claim that parental goodness needs completion. The analogy is limited, but it shows why gratuity and due are not contraries.

The relation to God is more radical and less commensurable. Everything offered is already received: the body that kneels, the reason that judges, the will that consents, the bread and wine placed upon the altar, the hour reserved for worship. Nothing crosses from an independent estate into divine possession. The return cannot make the accounts equal because there are no such accounts.

The paradox of the due

Being was not owed to me. I cannot repay it. Yet because I exist from God and for God, I owe the truthful use of what I have received.

The due cannot be paid off. It can only be lived.

3 Justice without Equivalence

3.1 The will to render the due

Aquinas receives the classical juristic definition of justice as the constant and enduring will to render to each one his right. The definition joins an objective term—what is due to another—to a subjective firmness—the will that knowingly and steadily renders it (ST II–II, q. 58, a. 1). Justice is not satisfied by a correct idea retained within the intellect. It rectifies action toward another.

God is not “another” alongside creatures within one common genus. Yet a rational creature is really distinct from God and really ordered to him. The special virtue governing acts of honor toward God is religion. It offers sacrifice, adoration, prayer, vows, and related acts because God alone is the first principle of creation and government and the last end of rational life (ST II–II, q. 81, aa. 1–4).

Religion belongs to justice, but not as a part capable of exact equality. Aquinas places it among justice’s potential

parts: something is genuinely due, but the full equality of strict justice cannot be achieved because the recipient infinitely exceeds the giver and the return can never equal the gift (q. 80, a. 1; q. 81, a. 5). The shortfall is not a defect in a willing creature's virtue. Equality is measured according to the creature's capacity and God's acceptance, not as equivalence between independent parties (q. 81, a. 5, ad 3).

An equal return is impossible. A true return is not.

3.2 Obligation without coercion

The word *obligation* often acquires the sound of an alien will pressing upon one's own. That picture confuses moral necessity with force. Aquinas distinguishes a necessity arising from constraint, which acts against the will, from the necessity of a command or of a means required for an end. The second does not destroy merit when one voluntarily does what is necessary (ST II–II, q. 58, a. 3, ad 2). Likewise, the service owed to God can be virtuous precisely insofar as it is rendered willingly (q. 81, a. 2, ad 2).

Duty is therefore neither self-creation nor alien coercion. The will does not invent the good by choosing it, but neither is a forced bodily movement an act of virtue. A just act is knowingly chosen for a due end and performed with stability. Obligation can bind the will without forcing it.

This distinction explains why the consent introduced in Part I—free agreement with the truth—is stronger than mere compliance. The Creator's authority is not produced by consent; nevertheless, the creature's moral act becomes whole only through consent. A person can attend worship to preserve a reputation, recite words without attention, or avoid external wrongdoing while inwardly preferring injustice. The external act may retain some objective order, but virtue requires the will's truthful participation.

Aquinas calls the will's readiness for divine service *devotion*. Devotion is not first an intensity of feeling. It is the act by which one gives oneself readily to what pertains to God's service (ST II–II, q. 82, aa. 1–2). Outward worship serves this inward act: embodied signs subject the mind to God and help arouse the devotion they express (q. 81, a. 7). Justice identifies the due; devotion names a will becoming ready to render it; charity will disclose how service can be animated by friendship with God.

3.3 Religion, faith, hope, and charity

Religion is not itself a theological virtue. Its immediate acts are things offered in divine worship; God is their end. Faith, hope, and charity have God himself as their proper object and can command religion's acts (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 5). These distinctions prevent the trilogy's movements from becoming three sealed compartments.

Faith receives God's truth and recognizes whom worship addresses. Hope relies upon divine help for communion and beatitude. Charity loves God for God's sake and directs the other virtues to their final end. Religion gives embodied and common form to the worship these theological virtues animate. The same participation in Mass may therefore be commanded by ecclesiastical law, be an act of religion, be formed by charity, be sustained by hope, and express faith. The distinctions do not divide the person. They show why “having to go” says too little about what the act can be.

Justice asks what belongs to another. Religion asks what belongs to God alone. Charity will not answer by declaring that nothing is owed. It will make the due filial.

4 The Living Sacrifice

Paul's “therefore” names the form of the answer. Because no one first gives to God, because all things are from him and through him and for him, and because mercy already precedes the response, the creature is to offer the body as a living sacrifice (Rom 11:35–12:1). The offering neither repairs a divine lack nor transfers an independently possessed good into God's estate. The body offered is already created; the reason renewed is already sustained; the will that consents already acts through powers it has received.

Sacrifice makes the return visible. Aquinas argues that natural reason recognizes some outward sign of the honor and subjection due to the first principle, while positive law determines its concrete forms. The outward offering signifies the inward sacrifice in which the soul offers itself to God (ST II–II, q. 85, aa. 1–2). The sign is false when it is severed

from the inward act, but the inward act is not therefore disembodied. An embodied and social creature answers with more than an intention hidden from the world.

Augustine gives the principle its ecclesial breadth. Every work truly ordered to holy fellowship with God is sacrifice; the person becomes an offering, works of mercy are referred to the supreme good, and the whole redeemed city is offered through the High Priest who first offered himself (*City of God* X.5–6, 20). Christian self-offering is not an autonomous ascent. It occurs within Christ’s prior oblation.

That qualification is decisive. The Eucharist is not deduced from First-Mover metaphysics. Christ’s sacrifice is a genuinely human oblation offered by the divine Son; it cannot be placed alongside creaturely returns as though commensurable with them. Christ is priest and victim; the Church’s self-offering depends wholly upon his perfect prior oblation. United to him, she offers the divine Victim and learns to offer herself with him (*Sacrosanctum Concilium* 47–48; *Lumen Gentium* 10–11). Work and prayer, family life and rest, hardship and acts of mercy become spiritual sacrifices when offered through Christ and brought into his Eucharistic offering (*Lumen Gentium* 34).

The answer thus becomes more searching than a private assent to dependence. It takes the received self as its matter: intellect, will, body, time, possessions, and common life. It does not merely acknowledge that creaturely being is from God. It places creaturely action within that truth.

Gift received. Due recognized. Self offered.

This is adoration carried from arrest into a form of life. Yet the form cannot be invented anew by every isolated will. A common body needs received words, signs, times, and authority. The living sacrifice therefore leads to command and law without being reducible to either.

5 Gift before Command

5.1 The indicative comes first

The Decalogue does not begin with a naked imperative. God first identifies himself through an act of deliverance: “I, the Lord, am your God, who brought you out of the land of Egypt, that place of slavery.” Only then follows “You shall” (Exod 20:2–3). At Sinai, covenantal gift precedes commanded response. The law does not address an anonymous will in an empty universe. It addresses a people already created, rescued, assembled, and claimed.

The order does not reduce command to gratitude. The commandments state genuine goods and prohibit genuine evils. Nor does it make obedience the price by which liberation is purchased after the fact. It shows the identity of the Lawgiver and the relation within which the law is heard. The one who commands is not Pharaoh under another name. He is the one who has broken Pharaoh’s claim.

The *Catechism* preserves this order. The Decalogue is understood within covenant and as a response to God’s initiative; moral existence answers a loving action that comes first (CCC 2060–2062). The first word recalls liberation before it makes the just demand that Israel accept and worship the one God (CCC 2084). Command is not severed from gift, and gift is not made morally mute.

5.2 Natural law disclosed and taught

The commandments are revealed, yet their moral substance is not arbitrary. Aquinas argues that the moral precepts of the Old Law belong to the natural law: they concern acts whose order to human good can be known by reason (ST I–II, q. 100, a. 1). Revelation gives them divine promulgation, gathers them into covenant, corrects a reason darkened in practice, and directs them within salvation history.

This double character matters. One cannot say that theft or murder became wrong only when words were inscribed on tablets. Neither can one treat revelation as superfluous because reason can in principle know moral truth. Human beings require instruction, correction, authority, and grace. The Decalogue states with divine clarity an order that belongs to the good of rational creatures.

Aquinas treats its precepts as primary specifications of justice. The general commands to love God and neighbor order the whole law; the Decalogue gives immediately knowable conclusions and directs acts toward the due (q. 100, a. 3). The first table orders the person to the common and final good, God. The second establishes justice among persons, forbidding what is undue and commanding that each receive the due (q. 100, a. 8).

The division blocks a false piety. Religion directs acts to God's honor, but it can command acts elicited by other virtues—for example, showing mercy to the afflicted, acting temperately and truthfully, and rendering justice to the neighbor (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 1, ad 1; a. 4, ad 1). One cannot honor the Creator by treating the creature's due as dispensable. The unseen God tests professed love in the treatment of the visible brother (1 John 4:20–21).

The two directions of the due

The first table forbids the creature to lie about God. The second forbids it to lie about the dignity and due of another creature. The same received life is ordered upward in worship and outward in justice.

5.3 Moral substance and specified observance

The Sabbath command displays another distinction. For Aquinas, its moral core is that a person should reserve some time for divine things. The determination of a particular time and ceremonial manner does not follow from natural reason alone (ST I–II, q. 100, a. 3, ad 2; a. 7, ad 5; II–II, q. 122, a. 4). The Christian Lord's Day is not therefore a simple continuation of every Mosaic Sabbath determination. Sunday commemorates Christ's Resurrection, fulfills the Sabbath's spiritual truth, and receives a definite common form in apostolic tradition and ecclesiastical law (CCC 2174–2177).

Here a general moral due receives revealed and juridical determination. The obligation to worship does not by itself tell a reader which day and liturgy current law appoints, whom it binds, what exceptions it recognizes, or which authorities are competent. Metaphysics establishes no hidden canon. The due becomes concrete through several ordered forms of law.

6 A Grammar of the Due

One phrase can conceal several kinds of necessity. "I have to" may report an unchosen fact, a moral judgment, a juridical command, or external compulsion. Four distinctions keep the question exact.

Four terms

Dependence

What is true whether or not I consent. A creature receives being; refusal cannot make it uncreated.

Duty

What ought to be chosen. Moral obligation addresses a rational and voluntary power; it binds without physically compelling it.

Precept

A duty, or a determinate mode of fulfilling one, commanded by competent authority for identified subjects and circumstances.

Culpability

Personal responsibility for a concrete failure, assessed by distinguishing matter, knowledge, freedom, intention, and relevant circumstances.

Dependence is ontological, not a statute or moral achievement. Duty is moral: reason identifies an act as fitting and binds the will without forcing it. A precept adds the act of a lawgiver. It may state a duty already knowable in substance or determine how a general duty is to be observed in common. Culpability concerns the responsible agent in a concrete act; it cannot be read directly from the bare statement of a rule.

These distinctions prevent several false inferences. "I depend upon God" does not by itself yield the canon specifying how the Sunday precept is fulfilled. "The Church commands this act" does not mean every external failure is equally culpable. "This act is owed" does not mean it is coerced, meritorious without consent, or incapable of love.

6.1 The layers of law

Law is an ordinance of reason for the common good, made and promulgated by one who has care of the community (ST I-II, q. 90). Aquinas's categories of eternal, natural, divine, and human law do not name four independent legislatures occupying one plane. Eternal law is divine wisdom ordering acts and ends. Natural law is the rational creature's participation in that order through practical reason. Divine positive law is used here for precepts revealed and promulgated by God within salvation history. Human positive law, civil or ecclesiastical, makes common determinations through competent authority.

The labels answer different questions. Is the norm knowable through practical reason? Has God revealed or commanded it? Has human authority enacted a common determination? A single practice can stand under more than one description without the sources becoming interchangeable. A theological reason does not by itself enact a canon; a canon does not exhaust the moral, ecclesial, or sacramental good it protects.

6.2 From general due to common form

Aquinas gives the passage in one distinction. Natural reason dictates that the human person do something in reverence for God. That *this* rather than *that* determinate act be required can be established by divine or human law (ST II-II, q. 81, a. 2, ad 3). Sacrifice likewise belongs generically to natural law, while its concrete signs receive positive determination (q. 85, a. 1, ad 1).

The Lord's Day follows this pattern without becoming a natural-law theorem. The moral due includes regular, outward, and common worship. Revelation supplies the Paschal mystery and Eucharistic good; apostolic tradition gives Sunday its Christian identity; ecclesiastical law specifies a common observance for identified subjects. Governing law and moral teaching distinguish impossibility and excuse from dispensation and commutation by competent authority. These are juridical distinctions, not private preference.

A concrete obligation must therefore be identified through its authority, promulgated text, jurisdiction, subjects, circumstances, and permitted relief. These questions do not weaken obligation. They identify it. Law states an obligation within a reality it did not originate.

7 Sunday: The Due Made Common

7.1 A received day

Sunday is first the Lord's Day. Christ rose on the first day of the week; the Christian assembly receives that day as the first feast and sign of the new creation (CCC 2174). St. Justin Martyr's second-century account already holds together readings, common prayer, Eucharistic thanksgiving, Communion, and aid to those in need (*First Apology* 67). The act is Paschal, sacramental, corporate, and merciful before it is described as a modern compliance question.

The juridical precept is therefore understood from a reality it did not create. Early Christians experienced the Sunday gathering as an inner necessity before later ecclesiastical law gave the duty more explicit universal form (*Dies Domini* 46–48). The Second Vatican Council calls Sunday the original feast day (*Sacrosanctum Concilium* 106). Neither historical spontaneity nor later obligation exhausts the practice. Love can recognize a need before law commands; law can protect the common good when recognition is weak or divided and when isolated choices cannot coordinate a body.

Because Eucharistic worship is the act of a body rather than an aggregate of private intentions, its common temporal form cannot be generated anew by each individual will. Sunday gives received time a Paschal and ecclesial order. It gathers persons who did not choose one another into one thanksgiving, interrupts labor's claim to ultimacy, and makes room for joy, rest, and mercy. The precept specifies a minimum; it does not measure the fullness of worship or love. A common minimum protects a good that private intentions alone cannot secure.

7.2 A bounded legal example

Current universal Latin law gives this good determinate juridical form. The Latin Code binds the persons identified by its general norms (CIC cc. 1 and 11). It names Sunday the primordial holy day of obligation (c. 1246 §1). On that day the faithful are obliged to participate in Mass and to refrain from works and affairs that impede the worship owed to God, the joy proper to the Lord's Day, or suitable rest (c. 1247). The second duty is governed by those goods, not by a universal prohibition of every form of work.

Participation in a Mass celebrated in any Catholic rite on Sunday or the preceding evening satisfies the Mass precept (c. 1248 §1). Reception of Holy Communion is a distinct sacramental and juridical question; the Sunday precept does not require reception at every Sunday Mass. Serious reason, impossibility, and dispensation by competent authority can all affect what is required, each with distinct grounds and effects. The *Catechism* names illness and care of infants as examples of serious reason; the Code treats impossibility and permits competent dispensation or commutation in defined circumstances (CCC 2181; CIC cc. 1245 and 1248 §2). None of these is private self-dispensation, and no general article can decide facts it does not possess.

Objective obligation and personal culpability must likewise be distinguished. Deliberate omission without serious reason concerns grave matter, but mortal culpability additionally requires full knowledge and deliberate consent (CCC 1857–1861, 2181). An external absence alone does not disclose all of those conditions. Exact questions of jurisdiction, persons bound, territorial holy days, relief, sacramental reception, and individual facts remain in the legal scope and research matrix rather than being made the center of this argument.

Works of mercy belong positively to the day. Family needs and important social service can justify necessary labor; Christians should also resist imposing avoidable work upon others and attend to those whose poverty denies them ordinary leisure (CCC 2185–2187). The day is not sanctified by making necessary care invisible.

The Sunday precept is therefore an instance of responsive justice, not its exhaustive inventory. The Church calls the faithful into the common act in which Christ gathers his body and gives what that body cannot supply for itself. Time received from God is returned as praise, rest, communion, and mercy—and received again as grace.

8 The Return Passes through the Neighbor

The upward and outward directions of the due cannot finally be separated. Religion gives God the honor owed to the first principle; justice gives the neighbor the good owed to another creature. Yet the same God creates both worshipper and neighbor, and the same received goods become the matter of praise, stewardship, and mercy. The unseen God tests professed love in the treatment of the person who can be seen (1 John 4:20–21).

This is also where a false return is exposed. Cult can be used as an attempt to settle an account: render a bounded observance, retain the remainder of the self as an independent estate, and imagine the debt closed. The prophets and Fathers refuse that bargain. Irenaeus insists that God neither hungers for offerings nor accepts sacrifice severed from justice (*Against Heresies* IV.17.1; 18.1–6). An external act of religion can be objectively due and still fail to express a self offered to God.

Gregory Nazianzen makes the logic concrete. He inventories existence, breath, understanding, knowledge of God, hope, creation's beauty, food, laws, social life, friendship, and the common goods of the earth. Having named what has been received, he identifies the return God asks: kindness and love, rendered through just stewardship toward the poor (*Oration* 14.23–25). The neighbor is not an interruption of the Godward answer. The gift has already placed the neighbor within it.

Chrysostom presses the Eucharistic point with deliberate force. The one who honors Christ's altar while neglecting Christ in the poor contradicts the honor he claims to render. His argument does not oppose beautiful worship to almsgiving; it denies that splendor can excuse abandonment of the afflicted (*Homilies on Matthew* 50.3–4). Justin's Sunday assembly had already joined Eucharistic thanksgiving to a collection for widows, orphans, the sick, prisoners, and strangers (*First Apology* 67).

Christ's sacrifice is perfect; mercy neither replaces the Eucharist nor adds to that sacrifice as though it were deficient. Mercy is a fruit and test of the communicant's incorporation into Christ. Worship directs mercy toward a good the self does not invent; mercy tests worship by exposing the temptation to confine religion to a protected interior life. The living sacrifice passes through both because body, possessions, and social life are among the goods received.

Justice therefore does more than add obligations after awe. It gives the apprehension a stable outward grammar: adore, keep faith, tell the truth, render what is due, protect rest, serve the vulnerable. These acts do not make dependence smaller. They make action agree with it.

9 The Grace of the Answer

9.1 Justice opens into hope

The due exposes another asymmetry. No creature can repay creation, and no creature can reach the supernatural end by natural powers. The first incapacity is permanent: no creature becomes equal to the Creator. In the sinner, grace both heals fallen nature and elevates it beyond its natural proportion. Justice reaches its limit without withdrawing the command; it opens into hope for the help that enables a filial act without making that act unreal.

The *Catechism* says that when God reveals himself and calls, a person cannot fully respond to divine love by his own powers. He must hope that God will give the capacity to love in return and to act according to charity's commandments (CCC 2090). Aquinas describes hope as tending toward future beatitude, arduous but possible through divine assistance (ST II-II, q. 17, aa. 1-2). Justice names the answer owed. Hope refuses the fiction that the answer can be made alone.

Hope excludes two evasions. Presumption appeals to mercy while refusing conversion, or trusts one's own powers as sufficient. Despair treats forgiveness, assistance, or beatitude as unavailable (CCC 2091-2092). Presumption says grace makes obedience unnecessary. Despair says obedience is futile because grace will not come. Neither error receives gift as gift.

Devotion joins this hope to the will. For Aquinas, consideration of divine goodness principally awakens readiness and joy; recognition of one's defect excludes presumption and introduces sorrow secondarily, while hope moves the person to rely upon divine help (ST II-II, q. 82, aa. 3-4). Creaturely finitude is not itself a moral defect, and spiritual joy is not a promise of sensible ease. Devotion names the will becoming available for divine service even when the act remains costly or dry.

9.2 The answer is also received

The First Mover is also the first mover of the return, though the supernatural claim is not deduced from the metaphysical proof. Aquinas holds both that God moves the will according to its voluntary mode and that even a free turning toward grace requires God's gratuitous inward motion (ST I-II, q. 10, a. 4; q. 109, a. 6). The response is received without becoming fictitious. Grace does not answer in place of the creature; it gives the creature the power to answer.

Gregory Nazianzen describes the movement within that priority. Grace comes first; fear takes determinate form in keeping the commandments; obedience purifies; purification opens toward illumination and the fulfillment of desire (*Oration* 39.8-10). The sequence is neither wages earned for vision nor a technique guaranteed to regulate feeling. It names how received truth can take hold of action and dispose a person for deeper knowledge of God.

Proper response does not make God less absolute. It brings judgment into act: the body kneels, time is set apart, goods pass to the neighbor, praise becomes common. As judgment becomes action, the fiction of self-sufficiency begins to lose its hold.

Hope deepens rather than narrows awe: the power to answer is itself gift. Justice can remove obstacles to peace; only charity directly unifies desire in the beloved good (ST II-II, q. 29, a. 3, ad 3). One question therefore remains: can the will embrace the good disclosed by duty, not merely as something commanded by the highest Lord, but as communion with the beloved?

What is owed can be freely loved. What is freely loved does not cease to be owed. That movement belongs to charity.

A Scope, Method, and Qualifications

A.1 Reader, question, and governing profiles

This is Part II of *The Creature Before God*, a discursive series for a serious general reader. Part I, *Ontological Vertigo*, treats the apprehension of asymmetric dependence and the fork of recoil or adoration. This article asks how the response becomes a living sacrifice, how obligation can be freely rendered, how worship takes common form, and how justice passes through the neighbor. The current universal Latin Sunday obligation is a bounded illustration, not the article's principal subject. Part III treats charity and the filial perfection of the return.

The article deliberately combines theology and canon law under the discursive-articles profile. Metaphysics, Scripture, patristic witness, Thomistic moral theology, and authoritative Catholic teaching govern the account of gift, justice, religion, command, grace, hope, and charity. Canon law governs only the identified juridical conclusions. A theological reason does not by itself enact a canon; the existence of a canon does not settle every theological interpretation or personal culpability judgment.

"Due return," "responsive justice," the four-term grammar of dependence, duty, precept, and culpability, and the language of ontological vertigo's ongoing resolution are project synthesis. *Religion* is used principally in Aquinas's technical sense: the moral virtue annexed to justice that renders worship to God. It is not used as a synonym for the theological virtues or for every institutional feature of a religious body.

Source class	Function in the article	Governing boundary
Sacred Scripture	Supplies creation and mercy before response, covenant before command, the Decalogue, worship and justice, the unrepayable gift, and the living sacrifice.	Exegetical synthesis remains bounded by the cited passages; no single verse is made a complete theory of law.
Patristic witness	Shows divine non-need, command for creaturely good, common Sunday worship, grace-enabled obedience, and self-offering in Christ.	Representative witnesses are not a mechanical consensus count or current legislation.
Thomistic theology	Provides justice, religion, unequal due, moral necessity without coercion, devotion, kinds of law, natural and positive determination, grace, hope, and charity's formal role.	School theology and adopted synthesis remain distinct from dogma and current canon law.
Catechetical and conciliar teaching	Governs the doctrinal account of moral law, Church precepts, the Decalogue, the Lord's Day, culpability, hope, worship, and common liturgical life.	The <i>Catechism</i> is authoritative teaching, not the promulgated text of the Latin Code.
Current Latin canon law	Establishes subjects, feast-day duties, satisfaction, impossibility, dispensation, commutation, and territorial competence.	The official Latin text, amendments, jurisdiction, particular law, and facts control; no individual case is adjudicated.
Project synthesis	Orders gift, due, precept, fault, hope, and self-offering into Part II of the series.	The terminology and literary movement are not attributed wholesale to any source.

A.2 Legal scope and currentness

Element	Controlling scope	Limit
Governing body of law	1983 Code of Canon Law as amended; universal law of the Latin Church.	CIC c. 1 excludes applying the Latin Code as such to Eastern Catholics; CCEO c. 881 and proper Eastern law are not analyzed.
Authoritative text and translation	Promulgated Latin and applicable later Latin legislation control; Holy See English pages are working reference renderings.	English wording does not displace the official text, canonical tradition, or a later promulgated norm.
Persons and territory	CIC cc. 1, 11–13 and 1246–1248; no named territory beyond universal law.	Other holy days, dispensations, and observance can depend upon episcopal-conference, diocesan, proper, or other applicable law.
Material facts	Abstract adult Latin Catholic with sufficient use of reason; no serious reason, impossibility, dispensation, commutation, privilege, or special law unless expressly discussed.	Real cases require complete facts and competent pastoral or canonical judgment.
Currentness	Official Code pages, the Holy See code and amendment archive, and the Holy See’s published compilation of authentic interpretations checked through 20 July 2026.	No located amendment or published authentic interpretation modified CIC cc. 1246–1248 in a way material to this article. This bounded audit is not proof against unpublished or unexamined particular or proper law.
Advice boundary	General theological and canonical study.	Not legal or canonical advice, a decree, a culpability judgment, or a substitute for a pastor, confessor, competent authority, or qualified canonist.

A.3 Included and excluded scope

Included are Rom 11:33–12:5, Exod 19–20, Psalm 116, the Decalogue’s twofold order to God and neighbor, Irenaeus on divine non-need, Augustine on true sacrifice, Gregory Nazianzen and Chrysostom on gift and mercy, Justin on the unified Sunday assembly, Aquinas on justice, religion, sacrifice, devotion, grace, and hope, Vatican II on Eucharistic and ordinary self-offering, the *Catechism*’s treatment of Church precepts and Sunday, and current universal Latin law in CIC cc. 1, 11, 85–93, 1244–1248, and 912–923 where separately noted.

Excluded are a comprehensive treatise on moral theology, virtue, conscience, sin, sacramental theology, liturgy, ecclesiology, or canonical interpretation; a calendar of territorial holy days; national conference and diocesan norms; Eastern Catholic law beyond naming the boundary; obligations of clerics or religious arising from office, vows, constitutions, or proper law; remote-participation questions; Eucharistic reception in irregular or disputed circumstances; canonical penalties; and any judgment about a named person’s obligation, excuse, sin, or imputability.

The Sunday case is illustrative, not exhaustive. The Ten Commandments and the Latin Sunday precept do not stand at the same level of authority. The article does not flatten natural moral law, revealed divine law, and ecclesiastical positive law into one inventory.

A.4 Material qualifications

1. Creation is neither compelled by a lack in God nor antecedently owed to a recipient not yet existing. Genuine created dues arise within the order willed by divine wisdom (ST I, q. 21, a. 1, ad 3).
2. “Debt” and “return” are analogical, not commercial. No creature confers actuality, beatitude, or utility upon God or makes God a debtor by worship.
3. Religion is a moral virtue annexed to justice because worship is due but cannot be rendered in absolute equality. It is not itself faith, hope, or charity (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 5).

4. The necessity of command differs from physical or psychological constraint. Obligation does not eliminate voluntariness, while external compliance alone does not constitute complete virtue.
5. Natural reason grounds worship generically; determinate rites and times can arise from divine or human positive law (ST II–II, q. 81, a. 2, ad 3; q. 85, a. 1, ad 1).
6. The Decalogue is revealed and expresses natural moral law. Its moral substance, its covenantal promulgation, and its ceremonial or juridical determinations must be distinguished.
7. Sunday fulfills the Sabbath’s spiritual truth in the Paschal mystery; it is not identified with every Mosaic Sabbath determination (CCC 2174–2176).
8. CIC c. 1247 contains both Mass participation and festal-rest duties. The latter is governed by what impedes worship, joy, works of mercy, and appropriate rest, not by a universal ban on all work.
9. Participation in Mass and reception of Holy Communion are distinct juridical and sacramental questions. CIC cc. 912–923 govern reception; this article decides no sacramental-access case.
10. Excuse, impossibility, dispensation, and commutation have different grounds and effects. Private preference is not competent dispensation.
11. Objective grave matter and mortal culpability are distinct. Full knowledge and deliberate consent must be established; a general article cannot judge a person’s soul (CCC 1857–1861).
12. Violation of a moral or disciplinary norm does not without an applicable penal norm establish a canonical delict or penalty.
13. Hope is not a species of justice. It trusts divine assistance for the arduous supernatural good; presumption and despair each falsify that trust.
14. Grace does not abolish command or secondary agency. The New Law’s inward gift heals and elevates the person to act freely (ST I–II, q. 106, aa. 1–2).
15. Charity perfects and commands the acts of other virtues by ordering them to the final end. It does not make injustice or impiety optional (ST II–II, q. 23, a. 8).
16. The living sacrifice is neither autonomous nor commensurate with Christ’s. The Church’s self-offering depends wholly upon union with her High Priest and Victim and his perfect prior oblation.
17. Worship is not proposed as therapeutic self-management. Its objective truth and formal fruits do not promise sensible calm, and continuing disturbance is not treated as evidence of refusal.
18. The resolution at issue does not reduce dependence. Justice, religion, and hope bring action into agreement with it; charity’s direct unification of desire remains the subject of Part III.

A.5 Translations, rights, and review

Scripture is cited by book and locus, with short working-English phrases checked against the Holy See-hosted NAB witness. Patristic working English comes from identified public-domain ANF or NPNF witnesses. Aquinas is cited by work, part, question, article, and reply; Latin loci are governed by the *Corpus Thomisticum*, with public English used as an aid. Official Catholic and canonical texts retain their own status. No bulk source text, modern commentary, or source-site wrapper is incorporated.

The legal currentness audit and core online witnesses were checked through 20 July 2026; the newly added patristic, conciliar, and Thomistic loci were checked on 21 July 2026. This is a source-audited working study. It has not received independent scriptural, patristic, Thomistic, moral-theological, liturgical, canonical, literary, or ecclesiastical review. It claims no imprimatur, nihil obstat, legal opinion, or ecclesiastical approval.

B References

Sacred Scripture

- Exod 19:3–6 and 20:1–17; Deut 5:1–22; Psalm 116:1–19, especially vv. 12–19; Matt 22:34–40; John 14:15; Rom 11:33–12:5 and 13:8–10; Jas 1:22–27; 1 John 4:19–21 and 5:3. Short English wording is used as a working rendering; Scripture and translations retain their own status.
- Holy See-hosted New American Bible working witnesses: Exodus 20, Psalm 116, Romans 11, and Romans 12.

Authoritative Catholic witnesses

- Second Vatican Council, constitution *Sacrosanctum Concilium* (4 December 1963), nos. 7, 10–12, 14, 47–48, and 106, on Christ’s sacrifice, the faithful’s self-offering with the divine Victim, liturgical participation, and the Lord’s Day; official English.
- Second Vatican Council, dogmatic constitution *Lumen Gentium* (21 November 1964), nos. 10–11 and 34, on the baptized offering spiritual sacrifices, the faithful offering the divine Victim and themselves with him, and ordinary life offered through Christ; official English.
- *Catechism of the Catholic Church* 1730–1748 (freedom and responsibility); 1854–1864 (grave matter and culpability); 1950–1974 (eternal, natural, old, and new law); 2030–2043 (the Church’s moral teaching and precepts); 2060–2082 (covenant, Decalogue, and natural law); 2084–2100 (faith, hope, charity, adoration, prayer, and sacrifice); 2168–2195, especially 2174–2187 (Sabbath, Lord’s Day, Sunday obligation, serious reason, rest, and mercy). Official English pages: culpability, moral law, Church precepts, faith, hope, and charity, and the Lord’s Day.
- St. John Paul II, apostolic letter *Dies Domini* (31 May 1998), especially nos. 6–8, 18–20, 31–34, and 46–53, on the Paschal, ecclesial, moral, and juridical dimensions of Sunday; official English.

Patristic witnesses

- St. Irenaeus of Lyons, *Against Heresies* IV.14.1–2, on divine non-need, service for the creature’s good, and fellowship with God; IV.17.1 and 18.1–6, on sacrifice, justice, and offerings that do not supply a divine need. Alexander Roberts and William Rambaut’s 1885 ANF working English: IV.14, IV.17, and IV.18.
- St. Justin Martyr, *First Apology* 67, on the Sunday assembly, Scripture, common prayer, Eucharistic thanksgiving and Communion, and care of those in need; Marcus Dods and George Reith’s 1885 ANF working English, online witness.
- Augustine, *City of God* X.1, 3, 5–6, and 19–20, on *latria*, true religion, outward signs, every work ordered to holy fellowship with God as sacrifice, the redeemed city offered through Christ, and God as needing no offering; public-domain NPNF working English, online witness.
- St. Gregory Nazianzen, *Oration* 14.23–25, on received existence and created goods answered by kindness, love, and just stewardship toward the poor; Holy See-hosted working excerpt. See also *Oration* 39.8–10, on prior grace, commandment, purification, illumination, and desire; NPNF working English.
- St. John Chrysostom, *Homilies on Matthew* 50.3–4, on honoring Christ’s Eucharistic body without neglecting Christ in the poor and on almsgiving alongside liturgical splendor; public-domain NPNF working English, online witness.

Thomistic framework

- St. Thomas Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I, q. 21, a. 1, especially ad 2–3, and a. 4, ad 4, on divine justice, derivative created dues, and God’s owing no debt to creatures; q. 44, a. 4, on God as final cause.
- Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* I–II, q. 10, a. 4 (divine motion according to the voluntary mode); q. 90, aa. 1–4; q. 91, aa. 1–5; q. 94, aa. 1–6 (law, its kinds, and natural law); q. 100, aa. 1, 3, 7, and 8 (the Decalogue, natural law, the two tablets, and moral versus determinate observance); q. 106, aa. 1–2 (the New Law chiefly as inward grace); q. 108, a. 4 (precepts and counsels); q. 109, especially aa. 2–4, 6, and 8 (the need of grace and the graced turning of the will).
- Aquinas, *Summa theologiae* II–II, q. 17, aa. 1–2 (hope and divine assistance); q. 23, a. 8 (charity as form of the virtues); q. 29, a. 3 (justice, charity, and peace); q. 58, aa. 1–4, especially a. 3, ad 2 (justice and necessity of command without constraint); q. 80, a. 1 and q. 81, aa. 1–7 (religion as an unequal part of justice, its acts, and relation to the theological virtues); q. 82, aa. 1–4 (devotion, meditation, joy, and hope); q. 85, aa. 1–4 (sacrifice and natural versus positive determination); q. 122, a. 4 (the Sabbath precept).
- Governing Latin loci checked through the Corpus Thomisticum Leonine-text corpus. The New Advent Summa served as a working public English index; particularly relevant English aids include justice, religion, devotion, the Decalogue, and the New Law. Work and exact locus take precedence over either site’s wording.

Current Latin canon law

- John Paul II, apostolic constitution *Sacrae disciplinae leges* (25 January 1983) and the 1983 *Codex Iuris Canonici* as amended. CIC c. 1 (Latin jurisdiction); cc. 7–22, especially 11–18 (promulgation, persons bound, territory, doubt, interpretation); cc. 85–

93 (dispensations); cc. 912–923 (Eucharistic reception); and cc. 1244–1248 (sacred times, feast days, obligation, satisfaction, impossibility, dispensation, and commutation).

- Official Latin: Book I and Book IV. Holy See-hosted working English: cc. 7–22, cc. 35–93, and cc. 1244–1253.
- Currentness controls checked through 20 July 2026: Holy See Code and amendment archive; Dicastery for Legislative Texts, published compilation of authentic interpretations. No located act amended or authentically interpreted CIC cc. 1246–1248 in a way material to this article.
- Eastern boundary only: CCEO c. 881 contains the Eastern common-law feast-day obligation and preserves the prescriptions or legitimate customs of each Church *sui iuris*. It is not analyzed or replaced by the Latin canons in this article.

C Generation Metadata

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Model: GPT-5-based Codex **agent**; **unexposed:** exact model identifier and model qualifiers

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (theological, Thomistic, patristic, canonical, source-audit, drafting, and editorial roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

Agent/runtime: OpenAI Codex agents (series-wide grammatical, semantic, theological-weight, literary, source-consistency, drafting, typesetting, and production-review roles); Codex CLI 0.144.6; API workspace; **unexposed:** server revision

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